1.3 Trails to the West

Think of times when you've had several choices in front of you. In the mid-19th century, westward-bound Americans had to decide which road—or, more accurately, which trail—they would take.

MAIN IDEA Between 1841 and 1866, as many as a half million Americans followed trails to new lives in the West.

TRAVELING BY TRAIL

The story of one of the most important trails to the West begins in 1821, the year that Mexico won its independence from Spain. Under Spanish rule, trade with the United States had been heavily restricted. Mexico was eager to support individual land ownership and trade with the United States. Settlements at Santa Fe and Taos in the New Mexico territory, then part of Mexico, were ideally located for Mexican trade with the westernmost territories.



In 1822, a trader named William Becknell opened a new route that covered a distance of more than 900 miles from Independence, Missouri, to Santa Fe. Soon other traders began using this route, which became known as the **Santa Fe Trail**. They hauled their goods in caravans of covered wagons, similar to Conestoga wagons. Near the trail's western end, traders used a branch of the trail called the Cimarron Cutoff so they could avoid crossing the rugged Sangre de Cristo (SAHN-gray day KREE-stoh) Mountains.

From Santa Fe, traders traveled to the Pacific coast along the **Old Spanish Trail**, through territory controlled by Mexico. They brought Mexican woolen goods across the trail to trade for horses in California. Extending across high mountains and the scorching Mojave Desert, it was the most dangerous and difficult of the trails.

In the midst of building a new nation, Mexico struggled to govern its settlements along the American border, where traders and settlers from both countries lived. Cultural clashes over such issues as slavery—which had been outlawed in Mexico—were common.

The Santa Fe Trail represented only one of several important routes to the West. Independence was also the starting point for two other important

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trails. The **Oregon Trail** led to the Oregon Country in the Northwest. This region included the present-day states of Oregon, Washington, and Idaho as well as parts of Montana and the Canadian province of British Columbia.

In 1846, the United States and Great Britain signed a treaty setting the boundary between their territories in the Oregon Country. The treaty settled disputed land claims between the two nations, and the resulting stability encouraged even more American settlers to move to the **Oregon Territory**, the American portion of what had been Oregon Country. Between 1840 and 1860, from 300,000 to 400,000 Americans traveled the Oregon Trail. By 1860, about 52,000 people had settled in the new state of Oregon. Many settled in the fertile valley of the Willamette River located at the end of the trail.



The National Museum of American History, Washington, D.C.

This sunstone carved from limestone is one of 30 that adorned the grand temple of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, completed in 1846 in Nauvoo, Illinois, by architect William Weeks. Images of the sun, moon, and stars are important to Mormon symbolism and may pertain to the Old Testament story of Joseph. Joseph Smith said that a sun with a face like this had come to him in a vision.

THE MORMON TRAIL

Some trails were forged by people seeking new economic opportunities. But others were inspired by the religious faiths of the travelers. One of those was the **Mormon Trail**. In 1830, Joseph Smith founded the Mormon religion, the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, in New York. Smith and his followers moved west, establishing a community in Nauvoo, Illinois. There, because of the economic and political power they had achieved, they suffered harassment from their non-Mormon neighbors. When a mob killed Smith, the Mormons' new leader, **Brigham Young**, decided to move even farther west so that he and his fellow Mormons could practice their religion freely.

In 1846, Young led an **exodus**, or mass departure, of Mormons. They traveled westward until they reached the Missouri River near present-day Omaha, Nebraska. After wintering there, they continued west, sometimes following the Oregon Trail. When they neared the **Continental Divide**, the high point in the Rocky Mountains that divides the watersheds of the Atlantic and Pacific oceans, they headed southward into territory still owned by Mexico. After an arduous trek over the Rockies, they reached the Great Salt Lake. There, in present-day Utah, Young declared that they had reached their destination, and they established the community of Salt Lake City.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Where did the Santa Fe, Oregon, and Mormon trails begin and end?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did the Mormons move west from Illinois?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** What major physical features did all or most of the trails shown on the map share?

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